

# Workplace Readiness Skills — Work Ethic

Standard 1.1.1 | Personal Qualities & People Skills

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Period: \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_

## ■ STANDARDS CONNECTION

Industry partners consistently rank Work Ethic as the #1 thing they look for when hiring — above technical skill. Showing up, staying on task, and doing more than the minimum are the behaviors employers notice first and remember longest.

## What Is Work Ethic?

Work ethic is the combination of values and behaviors that shape how you approach your job every day. It is not just about working hard — it is about working consistently, showing up reliably, taking direction without complaint, and bringing motivation to your tasks even when no one is watching.

| Term                          | What it means at work                               |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Punctuality                   | Arriving on time — every time. Not occasionally.    |
| Reliability                   | Following through on what you say you will do.      |
| Self-motivation               | Finding the next task without being told.           |
| Willingness to take direction | Accepting feedback and instruction without arguing. |
| Staying on task               | Keeping personal distractions out of work time.     |

## Part 1 — Ranking Activity

Below are 8 employee behaviors. **Rank them from 1 (strongest work ethic) to 8 (weakest).** Write your ranking number in the left column. Then write your rationale for your **top 3** and **bottom 2** choices below. **Circle the one item you think is most debatable.**

| Rank  | Employee Behavior                                                                                  |
|-------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| _____ | Arrives 5 minutes early every day and is ready to work at start time.                              |
| _____ | Does exactly what is assigned — nothing more, nothing less — and leaves the moment the shift ends. |
| _____ | Calls in sick on Mondays and Fridays three times a month, always with a different excuse.          |
| _____ | Stays late without being asked when the team is behind on a deadline.                              |

| Rank  | Employee Behavior                                                                 |
|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| _____ | Completes tasks efficiently but spends 20 minutes per hour on personal phone use. |
| _____ | Asks for more work when finishing early instead of waiting around.                |
| _____ | Argues every time a supervisor gives corrective feedback.                         |
| _____ | Shows up on time but visibly does the minimum and watches the clock.              |

**Rationale — My Top 3 choices:**

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**Rationale — My Bottom 2 choices:**

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## Part 2 — Scenario Questions

*Read each scenario carefully. Respond in **complete sentences**. One-word or one-sentence answers will not receive full credit. Support your position with reasoning.*

### SCENARIO 1

An employee who is always on time, follows every rule, and never misses a shift — but does the absolute bare minimum and shows zero initiative — versus an employee who is occasionally 5 minutes late but consistently goes above and beyond, helps coworkers, and takes on extra tasks without being asked.

**Which employee demonstrates stronger work ethic overall, and why? Is punctuality enough on its own? Defend your position in at least 3 sentences.**

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### SCENARIO 2

Your supervisor asks you to stay late with no additional pay because a client deadline moved up unexpectedly. You have personal plans that evening.

**Is staying late without extra pay a sign of strong work ethic, or is it being taken advantage of? Where is the line between work ethic and exploitation? What would you actually do, and why?**

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### SCENARIO 3

Someone calls in sick when they are not physically ill because they are mentally exhausted and need a day to recover. They have not used any sick days this year and their work quality is otherwise excellent.

**Is this a work ethic failure or a reasonable professional decision? Does it matter that they have never done it before? How should workplaces think about mental health days? Give your honest opinion.**

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### SCENARIO 4

Hector consistently outperforms every coworker in his department on individual tasks. But he refuses to help others, never does anything extra, and leaves exactly at quitting time. He has been passed over for promotion three times.

**Do you think it is fair that Hector keeps getting passed over? What is he missing, and why do employers value it? What would you tell him if you were his mentor?**

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### SCENARIO 5

A new employee notices that several experienced coworkers regularly spend the last 30 minutes of their shift doing almost nothing because "that is just how it works here." The supervisor has never said anything about it.

**Should the new employee follow the group behavior or maintain their own standard? What are the risks of each choice? What does this tell you about workplace culture and work ethic?**

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### ■ PEER COMPARISON

Find a classmate and compare your answer to Scenario 2. Write **one thing that was different** about how you each responded — and explain which response you think is stronger and why.

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■ **RESEARCH EXTENSION** (if time allows)

Search "what employers mean by work ethic" or visit **indeed.com/career-advice** and find one specific behavior employers cite as a work ethic signal. Write 3 sentences: what it is, why employers value it, and whether you currently demonstrate it. **OR** — describe a real situation you have personally witnessed where someone's work ethic had a visible impact on their job or team.

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➤ EXIT TICKET — detach and hand to your teacher on the way out

## Exit Ticket — Standard 1.1.1: Work Ethic

Personal Qualities & People Skills

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Period: \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_

### REFLECT & RESPOND

Describe one specific work ethic behavior you plan to demonstrate at your next job or internship — and explain why that behavior matters to employers in your career pathway. Be honest and specific. Write at least 3 complete sentences.

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*This standard is assessed on the Nevada WRS exam. Your honest, thoughtful reflection here helps you think like a professional — which is exactly what the exam tests.*